

communities with a tradition of big families and from the lower class of the society. Muslims have a mean average of 4.92 children to women in the 45-49 age; Buddhists are at 3.87 and Hindus at 3.77. At work sites of the National Rural Employment Guarantee Act (NREGA) or in urban slums, families with a high number of children are in a majority. M.L. Jain, director, reproductive and child health, Rajasthan, says: "We must provide child-spacing kits at NREGA sites to reach out to couples who are inclined to having big families."

Bhanwar Lal Gujjar, 40, and Mana, 35, a couple who work at a NREGA project, have four sons and seven daughters. Three of their daughters have four children, three of whom are just one year old. Their own youngest child Sonu at four months is younger than any of their grandchildren and Mana is pregnant again. Gujjar says he has never used a condom and no health worker has advised him about family planning aids. In many villages, a big family is used as a weapon of dominance. Hema Ram Grasia, 43, of Siawa village in district Sirohi and his wife Jamna Devi, 35, have 11 children.

He is a middle class farmer and his brood includes nine sons and two daughters. The youngest is four months old, the eldest 19. Every child of schoolgoing age gets free education, books and hostel accommodation. He has basic luxuries such as a refrigerator and television and is proud of his supersized family. "It is my fourth generation of more than nine children," Grasia says. His rationale: "To be a big person in our village, the family must have numbers." Nurses and anganwadi workers have told him to stop but he says his wife never asked him to stop. She is equally unconcerned. "I enjoy a big family," she says.

In other parts of the country too, large families are socially acceptable, even desirable. A 2008 study in the rural areas of Budgam district in Jammu and Kashmir interviewed 430 married women between 15 and 49 years. It found that more than 25 per cent had more than four children while 18 per cent had four. More than 93 per cent said the ideal number of children in their family must exceed two and only 6.8 per cent voted for two children. This attitude, along with the



KESHA RAM SANSI, 44
COBBLER WITH RAGPICKER WIFE

They have eight children, of whom two are blind, including the eldest one Gulab Rai. His wife Bhurki is a ragpicker and together they earn about Rs 160 a day. They have never heard of family planning, sterilisation or the need to have a small family.

HEMA RAM GRASIA, 43

The couple has 11 children and the schoolgoing ones avail of free education and hostel. He says that a big family is a necessity to be powerful in a village.



universal preference for a son, is a major reason for the failure of successive family planning programmes. The study concluded: "The two-child norm is a distant dream. Fifty-nine per cent had already breached it." This is far higher than the National Health Survey III which put the number of such couples at 39.7 per cent. The situation is similar or worse in states like Uttar Pradesh, Bihar, Madhya Pradesh, Orissa and regions carved out as separate states. The District Level Household Survey, 2002-03, revealed that 21.2 per cent of the 15,811 couples interviewed in Uttar Pradesh had five or more children.

Many official schemes tend to ignore big families as a disincentive. Says S.D. Gupta, director, Indian Institute of Health Management and Research (IIHMR): "Long back, we decided to leave out families with more